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Roll for Initiative: Balancing Player and Party in Library D&D Games

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ABSTRACT

Since its inception in the mid-'70s, *Dungeons & Dragons* (D&D) has been drawing players into collaborative quests. Increasingly, public libraries are hosting D&D games. Researchers observed D&D games hosted in two public libraries and interviewed participants, seeking to learn: *How do D&D games in libraries foster individuality and community?* Players pursue individual interests while also acting as considerate party members. Libraries provide D&D-related resources and participants find library games especially welcoming. The library enacts its role as a democratic institution by allowing a diverse group of people to play with a balance between individual and community. Other public libraries may be inspired to create their own D&D program or host similar events of interest to their staff and patrons.

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Introduction

"You find yourself in a tavern. All around you is the smell of good food and strong mead. The air is filled with loud laughter and discussion as a bard plucks a lilting tune from her lute in the far back corner. You are weary from travel and in need of rest and food. As you approach the bar and sit, the bartender, a large goliath figure approaches you, cleaning a glass. He gives you an appraising look and greets you, "Welcome Stranger."

Many beloved *Dungeons & Dragons* (D&D) campaigns have begun in a tavern. Each player enters as a stranger and leaves with other adventurers as companions in search of fame, gold, or justice. Over the course of the game these players and the Dungeon Master (or Game Master) will work together to create a story that is entirely their own, using the structure of a game which has captured the minds of gamers for decades. In recent years, D&D games in libraries have become more and more common. In order to examine library-hosted D&D, it is relevant to explore the basic structure of *Dungeons & Dragons* as well as some of its history.

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Dungeons & dragons

Since its initial publication of a thousand copies in 1974, *Dungeons & Dragons* has become a behemoth of the Table-Top Role Playing Game industry (Riggs 2022). Its creators, Gary Gygax and Dave Arneson collaborated to develop the game based off of the rules system for another game Gygax had helped design called *Chainmail* and a world setting Arneson had established named *Blackmoor*. Although Gygax is often credited as the main creator of *D&D*, those who have researched the history of the game – such as Ben Riggs (2022) author of *Slaying the Dragon*, David M. Ewalt (2013) author of *Of Dice and Men*, and Jon Peterson (2021) author of *Game Wizards: The Epic Battle for Dungeons & Dragons*—consider the creation of the game itself to be a collaboration. Neither contributor could have shaped the whole game by himself.

D&D differentiated itself from earlier role-playing-games, which had mostly been war games based on real historical battles or time periods, by allowing players to create individual characters and through the addition of fantastical elements and settings. Gygax and Arneson created their own publishing company, Tactical Studies Rules (TSR), to publish the game. As Ewalt describes in *Of Dice and Men*, Gygax play-tested the fledgling game in his home of Lake Geneva, Wisconsin. His two children were among the first players to experience the game. Eventually Gygax set up regular game nights with local gamers and others from his war games group to test the content. Ewalt (2013) describes these sessions as a time when Gygax was “learning the game alongside his players and changing the rules based on their actions Their actions shaped Gygax and Arneson’s work, and the decades of games that followed” (69). In the nearly 5 decades since the game first took form it has spawned conventions, TV shows, movies and books. *D&D* even played a cultural role in the Satanic Panic of the late 1970’s and early 1980’s due to its depictions of witchcraft and demonic figures found in Western Christianity (Riggs 2022, 29). According to publishers of *Wizards of the Coast*, across its five editions, the game has been played by 50 million people as of 2020 (Wieland 2021). While the game has seen both rises and falls in prominence, there is some element which keeps players returning, sometimes decades later, as Ewalt illustrates in *Of Dice and Men*. Recently, there has been a resurgence in the game’s popularity. In conjunction, there has been a rise in *D&D* games hosted in public libraries, where children and adults alike can experience the game for the first time or return to it. Table 1 includes definitions of common *Dungeons & Dragons* terms.

Table 1. D&D definitions.

Dungeons & Dragons Game	A framework of rules and world settings that each adventuring party can use to guide their own story. This framework comes in the form of rule books and other published materials which players can refer to and use in their games
Dungeon Master 'DM'	A player who provides the rest of the players with the structure of the world around them and facilitates gameplay according to the rules set by the game books
Player Character 'PC'	A character which each of the non-DM players is in control of within the game. They make up the adventuring party and interact with the world around them to determine the story
Non-Player Character 'NPC'	A character played by the DM who may assist, fight, or otherwise interact with the party
Home Brew	Material for the game which is created by the DM rather than made by an official publishing company. This is in comparison to modules which provide DMs with most of the information needed to run a game
Character Statistics	Statistics unique to each character, determined by a variety of background factors such as class. These combine with a dice roll to determine the outcome of an action that a player character takes
Class	A classification for characters which determines gives the framework for aspects such as their skills and abilities.
Character Alignment	The moral compass that a character possesses which guides the decisions that the player makes on their behalf in the game

Motivation, interest, and belonging

Playing *D&D* is a time commitment. Gaming sessions often last hours and completing an entire campaign or storyline can take multiple sessions spanning weeks or months. *D&D* has also been around for decades, as described above. Given the time players are willing to put into playing *D&D* and the game's persistent appeal, it may be relevant to consider how motivation and interest are fostered and maintained. Studying human motivation, Hidi and Renninger (2006) have proposed a Four-Phase Model of Interest Development. This model considers that interest is formed by both affective and cognitive factors in four stages: "Triggered Situational Interest," "Maintained Situational Interest," "Emerging Individual Interest," "Well-Developed Individual Interest" (p114–115). Applied to *Dungeons & Dragons* then, interest must be triggered to join a *D&D* session. Then, interest must be fostered to keep players attending subsequent sessions. Interest in *D&D* may become an internally motivated curiosity and desire to learn. Interest in *D&D* and motivation to keep playing may be tied to a sense of belonging.

Hidi and Renninger (2006) and Deci and Ryan (2000) identify belonging in a social sense as a factor in the development of interest and motivation. Studies of belonging have identified four different paths to belonging. Members of a *D&D* campaign may follow several of these paths through play. These are the "communal relationship path," the "achievement path," the "group membership path," and the "brief social factors path" discussed by Hirsch and Clark (2019, 239). They mention that many people have given up on attaining fulfillment in all four paths of belonging and chose to instead focus on a few paths to create a greater

sense of belonging (248). It is interesting to note that in his book, Ewalt (2013) states:

When a group of people play a game together, they enter a sort of alternate reality where friendships form at an accelerated rate [...] as the game picks up, the players become engrossed in the experience; they stop being anxious scientists and become fighting birds of prey [...] Emotions run high, and they keep getting higher, joy, anger, excitement, fear, even the terror of (simulated) death. In this artificially accelerated and emotionally heightened social environment, bonds are forged quickly and forged strong [...] even when a game is over, the bonds that have been created persist. (119)

Ewalt's description appears to connect with the communal-relationship, achievement, and group membership paths.

Previous research also indicates that playing or performing together builds community bonds and can grant an individual "insider" status. For example, the anthropologist Clifford Geertz (1973) describes becoming "visible" to the Balinese community he was trying to study after attending an illegal cockfight that was raided. He says that the next morning, he and his wife "were suddenly the center of all attention, the object of a great outpouring of warmth, interest, and most especially amusement" (416). The locals were amused because Geertz and his wife had run away during the raid, just as the villagers had, instead of using their status as white researchers to get out of any trouble. But, in Bali "to be teased is to be accepted" (416). They had not only played with the villagers but had also assumed the same risks, forging a relationship that had not previously existed. One of the authors of the present article (Nelson 2019) has experienced the importance of playing with a community and being an insider. During previous research with a storytelling community she had performed with, the researcher was told by a participant, "It'd be different if you were an outsider . . . I'm sure of it" (39). Researchers in particular may play or perform with communities to gain trust, but they are only following the path anyone must take to become an "insider" with the community.

Further considering group membership and belonging, Ess (2014) argues that when people operate more in relation to others, as part of a group (we could say "party" in the *D&D* context) they "are required to *submit* to recognized authorities who exemplify mastery of a given practice" (618). He suggests the possibility that "the shift from more individual towards more relational conceptions of selfhood [may] weaken our commitments to the democratic practices of high modernity – including the foundational norms of justice, equality, and gender equality" (618). We understand this to mean that the individual does not matter as much and does not require equal treatment if too much importance is placed on the group and authority figure. In contrast, individuality is essential to democracy. Ess says "such a self thus requires and justifies the establishment of the modern democratic and liberal state. [...] Especially in Kantian terms, our always treating human autonomy

as an end-in-itself, never as a means only, implies precisely equality, equality of participation, and justice in the form of fair and equal treatment (625). The individual must matter for equality to make sense. Ess suggests that a hybrid individual/relational self is optimal, valuing both the individual self and the group (630). *D&D* provides an opportunity to play with concepts of self and party, and the library as a democratic institution is an interesting setting for *D&D*.

Much of the existing literature on *D&D* and similar games in libraries consists of advice for librarians. For example, several chapters in *52 Ready-To-Use Gaming Programs for Libraries* (Kroski 2020) provide suggestions on how libraries might implement tabletop gaming programs. Snow's (2008) article *Dragons in the Stacks* includes guidance on adding fantasy role-playing games to the collection. However, there are fewer research articles studying *D&D* hosted by libraries, meaning there is more to learn about what *D&D* games can offer to libraries and their patrons.

Materials and methods

Understanding that *Dungeons & Dragons* creates opportunities for players to experiment with their roles as individuals and as members of a party, and understanding libraries to be community centers and places for storytelling, we asked two questions: *How do library D&D games foster individuality?* And *How do library D&D games foster community?*

This study was approved by the University of Wisconsin-Whitewater Internal Review Board before research began. The IRB considered this study exempt from full review as it posed no greater risk to participants than the activities of daily life. We asked permission from libraries before attending their games to observe. We provided written informed consent to each interview participant and additionally secured informed consent from the parent of the minor we interviewed.

The researchers studied *Dungeons & Dragons* games hosted by two public libraries in the Midwest, attending games and interviewing librarians and participants. We use fantasy pseudonyms for the libraries and participants in this article. The Ulfgar Public Library holds *D&D* games online. They meet every two weeks through one Zoom link and use breakout rooms for the four games going on simultaneously. We observed the Ulfgar games twice and interviewed nine participants from Ulfgar. The Quarion Public Library holds *D&D* games in person at the library. There is an adult game that meets every two weeks. The all-ages games also occur every two weeks and they break up into as many tables as needed, usually two to three. We observed the adult game once and the all-ages games three times and interviewed five participants from Quarion. We provide additional information about the genders and roles of the interviewees in Table 2.

Table 2. Study participants.

Pseudonym	Library	Gender	Role
Diesa	Quarion	F	Player (all ages)
Frath	Quarion	M	Player (adult)
Harbek	Quarion	M	Player (adult)
Lander	Quarion	M	Library Director, Adult DM
Riswynn	Quarion	F	YA Librarian, All Ages DM
Aramil	Ulfgar	F	Librarian, <i>D&D</i> Coordinator
Baern	Ulfgar	M	DM
Carric	Ulfgar	M	DM
Galinndan	Ulfgar	M	DM
Paelias	Ulfgar	F	Player
Ruric	Ulfgar	M	Player
Silifrey	Ulfgar	F	Library Staff, Player
Stor	Ulfgar	M	Player
Travok	Ulfgar	M	Player

When the researchers visited each game for the first time, the librarians introduced us to the players and we briefly described our study. We observed the games quietly, taking fieldnotes. We wanted players to know we were there but also wanted to disturb the games as little as possible. Online, with camera and microphone off, the researcher disappeared into the background well. In person, the researcher remained more visible and players occasionally chose to interact with us. In our fieldnotes, we recorded start and end times, observations about the physical or virtual space, arrangement of players, interactions and side conversations between players, and a summary of how the story progressed during that session.

One of the researchers joined into an all-ages session at Quarion as a participant observer near the end of the study. The researcher took a pre-made character sheet, quickly familiarized herself with it, and played during that session as that character while simultaneously taking fieldnotes. Because this was near the end of the study and only occurred on one occasion, it is unlikely the all-ages table fully recognized the research as an “insider,” but perhaps appreciated the opportunity to “watch the watcher watch (Alexander Craft 2015, 12). By playing, the researcher put herself under their scrutiny and allowed the other players to judge what she had learned by watching them.

In the adult games, we asked players if they would like to volunteer to participate in an interview, and many did. We also approached the librarians who facilitated these sessions about participating in interviews. We were more cautious about recruiting in the all-ages game because parents were not always present, and we ended up interviewing one teen with parental consent. We asked participants questions about their experiences with the *D&D* games facilitated by the library as well as any gaming experiences they had had outside of the library. After one interview, a player suggested some additional questions, which we incorporated into the interview guide. The complete interview guide is available in [Appendix](#).

We analyzed fieldnotes and interview transcripts using qualitative coding. We used the program Otter.ai to transcribe interviews and used the collaborative platform Dedoose for coding.

Results

In the findings, we examine how participants pursued individual interests during *D&D* games hosted at the library, how they helped pursue party interests, and the unique role the library played in facilitating these *D&D* sessions.

Individual

We found that although players adventure as a party, they sometimes make individual choices that perhaps prioritize their own interests. This type of behavior was most pronounced in the Quarion all-ages games. We observed during one game: “The silly teen did weird stuff like burying herself in the sand, choosing to pass out and flopping like a fish” (Fieldnotes, May 10, 2022). During a previous month, at this same table made up mostly of children and teens, one young player tried to explore a hole in the floor, in spite of hinted warnings from the Dungeon Master (DM). A teen player had her character try to pick his character up and move him toward the door and safety. They spent several turns unsuccessfully rolling to overpower one another and both ended up stuck in a room that was filling with water (Quarion Fieldnotes, April 11, 2022).

For the young players, their more individual actions seem to be about exploration and acting out in ways that perhaps they cannot in real life. Their choices do not help their character achieve any personal goals within the game, nor do they help the party. Riswynn, the young adult librarian who DMed this table, thought that *D&D* helped these young players “express” themselves “through a character” (personal communication, April 21, 2022). “In this imaginary world, it’s almost as if you can do almost anything, you can be a person with magic, you can be a great brave fighter.” She stated as well that this play did help the young players “connect” with the others around them.

As a DM, Riswynn sometimes has to make choices about how to handle “different players [who] want to go in all the different directions.” She says, “it’s very difficult to tell the story with so many different perspectives” (personal communication, April 21, 2022). She usually finds a way to get them back together “whether it’s a magical being who suddenly transports them somewhere else or entraps them in a room. Or I find a good way to get them in an area where they have to work together is I put them in a maze.” Riswynn

supports the individuality of her players but also brings them back together when needed.

Another example of acting as an individual is taking the hero spotlight. In some ways, all members of the party are heroes on this journey together, but there are times when one party member steps up to do something extra heroic. Silifrey, from one of the Ulfgar games, recalled a moment from a previous campaign in which she stepped up during the “epic final battle” (personal communication, April 25, 2022). Instead of fighting or running away from the sorceress the party was facing, she wedged a broken spear into the cogs of the sorceress’s world-killing machine. Silifrey said that her party complimented her for coming up with this plan. *D&D* can provide Hirsch and Clark’s (2019) general-approbation path to belonging by allowing characters to achieve something difficult and gain renown within the group.

When asked about a favorite moment from a recent game, several players had stories like Silifrey’s in which they had taken the spotlight and succeeded. Paelias, also from an Ulfgar table, recounted a time when the party needed to shut off a valve in a poison gas-filled room. She suggested that she ties a rope around her waist, run in, turn off the valve, and when she passed out, her party could pull her body out using the rope. Paelias was “grateful that my teammates trusted me and had my back” (personal communication, May 6, 2022). A party member who tries to be the hero too often could easily become tedious, but when they do it once in a while (and especially if they are successful in their endeavors) they are celebrated by the rest of the party.

Sometimes players get a spotlight moment in situations that are not quite as life and death. Diesa, from the Quarion all-ages game, really enjoyed a moment in which she just got to do a fancy flip after rolling a “natural 20.” In response to the high roll, the DM Riswynn described Diesa’s character’s acrobatic leap in great detail, including an NPC (non-player character) bystander who applauded afterward.

When asked about advice to DMs, several participants mentioned the importance of giving each player some time “in the spotlight” (Baern, personal communication, April 25, 2022). Baern, a DM from one of the Ulfgar games, mentioned not only heroic opportunities during battles but also allowing characters to have their own subplots in the overall story. Aramil, the librarian running the Ulfgar games, also suggested DMs try to encourage shy players by asking “open-ended questions” about their character (personal communication, April 22, 2022).

Some of the Ulfgar DMs also mentioned the “rule of cool.” The DM can allow a character to do something that should not technically be possible within the parameters of the game, just because it is cool:

But there are other times where I like to really follow the rule of cool, where, let’s say a character wants to jump off the third story building, and take a bad guy with them. And

they tumble in the middle of the air to hit the ground. Under normal circumstances, like, yeah, you should be taking fall damage because you're falling out of a third story building. But they did it in such a cool dramatic way where they managed to grab this guy, jump out the window, and use them to break the fall. And so instead of him getting hurt, the other guy gets hurt. And like in that situation, I think breaking the rules to create the cool situation is more acceptable. It's something that makes them feel that they've done something grander. (Galinndan, personal communication, April 28, 2022)

This is another way the DMs can facilitate a player having an individual heroic moment.

The party may disagree with individual decisions a character makes. Ruric, a player from one of the *Ulfgar* games, talked about consequences to a player in a game he has been a part of outside the library. The character acted in a "morally questionable" way (Ruric, personal communication, April 22, 2022). Another player knocked the character out and the party took all his armor and weapons. Once the character was revived, they made him buy his stuff back.

A more common way in which a player might act out of character is actually to prevent their character from dying. Stor, from *Ulfgar*, said that players can be "very protective" of their characters (personal communication, May 5, 2022). After playing for hours and hours they may get attached and be less inclined to put their character in danger.

As a participant observer, one researcher experienced making a choice for the good of another character and then having an individual reaction to that decision as a player. From the fieldnotes:

Some players tried to talk to her [a non-player character] and she was very scared. I asked [the DM] if I could use my charm spell to calm her down. It seemed like a kind thing to do so she wouldn't be so scared. I did use the spell, but then I felt bad about it because she became unnaturally trusting of me. Did I deserve her trust, especially when I had magically manipulated her? (Quarion, May 10, 2022)

Players can instantly see the results of individual actions and can question for themselves how they feel about the consequences.

When players act as individuals, they may be taking advantage of the fantasy world to act in ways they normally cannot. They may step into the spotlight as heroes during battle and are often celebrated for doing so. Good DMs try to give each individual a chance in the spotlight. Consequences for disliked individual actions can come from the party or the DM. For the most part, we witnessed and heard about players playing with their ability to make individual choices in a way that was agreeable or at least tolerable to the rest of the party, and often for the good of the party.

The party

Dungeon master

D&D is run on a system that allows two roles for human participants: Dungeon Master and player. The Dungeon Master presents the game to the players and facilitates their adventure through the rules system provided by the publisher. The DM will describe the world around the players as well as provide non-player characters, or NPCs, for the player characters to interact with. Throughout the research and observation one aspect which caught the authors' attention was the role of the DM and how the individual in that role interacts with the other players and the game at large. This role seems to come with an inherent amount of power; however, research interviews indicated that many people saw the role of DM as a facilitator and fellow player rather than a divine figure in control of the world and story. One of the Ulfgar DMs, Carric, described the DM as "the narrator and also the supporting cast ... a facilitator of storytelling" (personal communication, April 22, 2022).

In a similar vein, one of the questions asked in each interview was what participants thought a DM should keep in mind while running a game. One player from Ulfgar suggested that DMs remember that the goal of the game is to create the story collaboratively.

The DM should keep in mind that it's not just their story. If they're stuck on their story in the way they want it to go, their party will have a bad time ... your party is going to change it. They're going to do things that are completely unexpected ... I told you about the time that our friend DM'd and he did a TPK (Total Party Kill) to us, right? He had a very rigid storyline. And we were all like, "No, we don't want to do that." And so he said "You have like no other options" It just like put a bad taste in everyone's mouth. You're ruining the game now. Now we're just playing your story. Instead of playing the story together. (Ruric, personal communication, April 22, 2022)

When examining this role, research indicated that a DM, while filling a separate role from that of the players, should not be aiming to create a predetermined story or to herd players in a specific way. Instead, DMs should focus on creating a sandbox that all players can explore and, when necessary, provide bumpers in the form of the game rules to help facilitate the playing of the game. The research indicated that players and DMs alike believed that the story being told should be informed by each person involved, regardless of role, and should be one that the community creates together.

Player interactions

One of the key aspects of *D&D* is the ability of player characters to interact with other player characters as well as the NPCs who populate the world around the party. The game requires at least two people to play, so during the research, the authors observed the dynamics between players, both in and out of game. In many instances researchers observed strong teamwork

dynamics displayed by both the player characters and DMs. Players were observed taking risks which threatened their own characters in order to assist other party members who were in danger. During one Ulfgar game, an individual playing a barbarian jumped off of a mountain to attack a dragon which was attacking the rest of the party. This character survived the fall but took a massive amount of damage and the player faced the real possibility of losing that character permanently (Ulfgar Fieldnotes, April 8, 2022).

A similar tendency to help fellow party members was also present in gameplay in ways that did not always relate to the action occurring in the story. In another session at Ulfgar there was an instance of a more experienced player walking another newer player through the leveling up process for his character. The more experienced player had more familiarity with the rules and was able to help the newer player while the DM focused on helping other players.

A game at Quarion was interesting to note because of the way the group went about making big decisions (Quarion Fieldnotes, March 19, 2022). Whenever there was discussion on where the party should go next or a difficult situation where the party needed to make a choice, the group would check in with each other to hear the whole party's thoughts. There were two players who tended to take the lead on interacting with NPCs, but they consulted with the less outspoken party members when making decisions. For example, when the party members needed to decide whether to move forward toward a group of goblins, each party member was asked their opinion and they took a vote. The party voted on major actions on several occasions throughout that game. Overall, observation indicates that players settle fairly quickly into teamwork and in many cases will be as helpful as they can be to another party member as both players and the characters they are portraying. This teamwork, which the framework of the game introduces, may contribute to building a sense of community, which many have observed as being an aspect of the game, and the *D&D* groups specifically that they enjoy.

Another interesting observation was that sometimes this sense of comradery can extend beyond the player characters to the NPCs that they interact with regularly. Baern told a story of how one of the player characters sacrificed themselves in the finale of a game to save an NPC who had become important to the party.

So when they got to the boss battle, they killed the big bad evil person and a really high level devil shows up to reclaim this warlock because the pact had been finalized and one of the characters sacrificed or wanted to sacrifice his character . . . to this powerful devil to save this NPC . . . that was a super meaningful thing that player did that I did not see coming . . . it was really potent, or really poignant. And that was awesome. I'll always remember that. (Baern, personal communication, April 25, 2022)

This suggests that the structure of the game can encourage the players to bond with their own characters as well as other characters including those not controlled by other players. This bonding may facilitate the sense of community many participants referenced in their interviews.

Carric, a DM from Ulfgar, also mentioned really finding a community in the library *D&D* game:

I have said before that I really enjoyed the people, both the players at my table, and then also the larger group. It is kind of playing into your overarching theme here, it is a sense of community. It is part of having a lot of people coming together for the same reason. And I mean, we have fun together, we enjoy spending time with one another, telling these stories about dwarves that drink too much and are numbered or named in order of their siblings . . . Just enjoy getting a bit of a break from the ordinary. (Carric, personal communication, April 22, 2022)

Throughout the study, researchers noted that the players of these games spanned across all demographics and Carric recalled that the groups are made up of “some of the most unlikely people” (personal communication, April 22, 2022). The library seems to serve as a connecting point, drawing in a vibrant and diverse group of players and giving them the opportunity to grow into a larger community through the story that they are telling together through their creative teamwork.

The idea of creative teamwork is present in the larger gaming community but is specifically prevalent in *D&D*, right back to the very beginning when Gygax and Arneson worked together to create the basic framework and when Gygax play tested with local gamers. This saturates every concept connected with the game and when participants were asked what advice they would give to other players this theme appeared often.

The goal is to have fun, and I’m harping on this point a lot. But that’s an important thing to do, both for yourself and for everyone else. Enjoy yourself. Don’t be afraid to set up opportunities for other players to also have fun. And also don’t be afraid to speak up. And also know when to let someone else speak. Have a balance of being active and part of a group without pushing people outside of it. And then also, again, be willing to try new things. Whether that’s something that you’re concocting some crazy plan or strange approach to a problem, or whether that’s someone else. Just playing along with your other players is one of the best things you can do I think. (Carric, personal communication, April 22, 2022)

D&D is a game which is designed to bring players’ enjoyment and have them solve whatever problems appear in front of them. No matter how small the party is, the game requires at least two people to work together to be successful. That creative teamwork that is accomplished through the players and DM coming together to tell a story seems to thread through player and DM interactions to create a larger community.

Beyond D&D

The sense of community can extend beyond the *D&D* game as well. Libraries are offering other programming centered on group play. Riswynn shared that her Teen Advisory Board (TAB) “wanted a game night. So we’re getting together all of the classic game boards. And we’re going to fill up the tables of different game boards and just game for like an hour in the community center” (personal communication, April 21, 2022). Diesa is on that TAB and is involved in the all-ages *D&D* game. She was interested in the planned game night but also said, “I’m not social. Personally, I think the library is for books” (personal communication, April 21, 2022).

Participants mentioned the library as a community space and providing *D&D* games was just a part of how they served the community. Travok asserted that people can go to the library for community. “Because you’re doing something to be in a group, and rather than going there just to be by yourself, but you’re doing this club thing, because you want to be, you know, in a more social setting” (Travok, personal communication, April 25, 2022). The social opportunity provided by the library was especially meaningful to patrons during the COVID-19 pandemic. A library employee and player, Silifrey, noted how marketing the library as a community space is also beneficial to the library, drawing patrons back in, post-pandemic. “Yeah, we still have good circulation numbers considering, because we do curbside service, and we’ve got a huge digital collection, which people have been using. And that went up. But we do want them, you know, to come back in the building” (Silifrey, personal communication, April 25, 2022). Patrons do not need to come to the physical building to access many of the materials and services the library provides but may return for the people they can be in community with there.

Aramil, who runs the online *Ulfgar* games, said that players will come to the library to see her. “And that way I get to sort of see everyone in person, which is a different experience than seeing online and they check in to see how I’m doing and I get to check in with them” (Aramil, personal communication, April 22, 2022). Their sense of community extends beyond the game to a real-life person they would like to interact with in person, and they come to the library to do so.

Side conversations during *D&D* sessions revealed relationships players had outside of the game. One researcher overheard children at the Quarion all-ages game talking about band and realized they went to school together. During the *Ulfgar* sessions, players with cameras on often revealed parts of their personal lives through what was visible in their room and might bond over other shared fandoms. For example, during a session one player asked another “What’s that mug?” The other player responded, “Star Trek,

Dr. McCoy” to the delight and amusement of many at the virtual table (Ulfgar Fieldnotes, April 8, 2022).

One participant, Ruric, discussed during the interview the experience of being “the only brown kid” (now adult) in a *D&D* game (personal communication, April 22, 2022). He had high hopes that fantasy role play could be a way for people to explore and better understand other identities in the real world:

Talking about, like you say, for example, you want to talk about queer identity, and you could put that into a fantasy world and have a lot more productive conversation than you can with, say, you put that into just me and us sitting across from each other and talking about it. And I know this is kind of like psychotherapy, puppetry, it’s sort of the same thing. But whatever helps, helps, you know, it’s easy for you to escape into a fantasy world and talk about issues that you need to discuss in a fantasy world. Cool. Let’s do that. You know, and I, I do think there’s some, like social psychological benefits to that. And I mean, heck, and to my point of wanting to reach people who wouldn’t normally play. So imagine if you’ve got, say, a very obvious stereotypical example here. But say you got a cisgendered, white male cop, and you have a queer gendered African American male assigned individual, and you sat them down, you said, Here’s your character sheet. And you made a character sheet, more in line with the opposite identity and have them play a game. And they have to go through the struggles that the other one has to go through. We were playing a game but you’re learning through the game. This is really hard. Well, this is unfair. Yeah, that does seem scary. And so I think that there’s some benefit to that. I think game theory and gameplay have the ability to kind of soften hard conversations and open the doors for things that wouldn’t normally happen. (Ruric, personal communication, April 22, 2022)

We did not observe *D&D* being used in this deliberate way to increase empathy and soften difficult conversations. However, one researcher experienced how *D&D* can allow players to consider the morality of certain decisions, as described above, after charming the frightened NPC. Play intentionally designed to increase empathy could be an area for future study.

Library

Participants repeatedly named two main benefits of having *D&D* games at the library. First, the library provided a regular time and place (physical or virtual) for the games. Many participants had been part of games with friends that fell apart because they could not find a time to meet regularly when everyone was available. During the COVID-19 pandemic, the library *D&D* games met online regularly, again creating stability for the campaigns. The library can help foster maintained situational interest (Hidi and Renninger 2006, 114) by providing an environment where continuation is reliable and not dependent on individuals but rather on an organization. Players appreciate this stability and are able to more fully commit themselves to games they know will meet regularly.

The second main benefit was the provision of DMs. Finding someone who is knowledgeable about the game and wants to be a DM can be difficult for friend groups. The libraries generally provide DMs in one way or another. At Quarion, the adult game and some of the all-ages tables had librarian DMs. One of the all-ages tables had a DM who came from the adult game, and another was a table of older teens who had their own ongoing game and mostly used the library for the space. Ulfgar started with DMs who had close ties to the librarian, Aramil. As the game grew, some players expressed interest in DMing and later took on new tables. Whether the DMs are actual library staff or not, the librarians running the games make sure there are DMs.

The Ulfgar Library especially provides resources in the library and in the *D&D* game. Library *D&D* may increase internally motivated curiosity and desire to learn and then facilitate this curiosity through the provision of resources (Hidi and Renninger 2006, 115). Ulfgar has many *D&D* books available to check out. The library has a 3D printer that can be used to create character figures. The library's subscription to the online platform Roll20 allows users to sign on even outside of game time and view digital versions of many of *D&D*'s print resources. With the exception of Roll20, library users would not need to be part of the library's *D&D* game to partake in these resources. Access to Roll20 is another benefit of playing *D&D* through the library. In addition, Ulfgar supports gaming beyond their own tables and even beyond *D&D*.

Finally, a benefit mentioned by some and intentionally created by the libraries is a "safe space" for all gamers. Some participants mentioned that being new to *D&D*, they were too intimidated to join a game at a game store. The library games are friendly to new players, with DMs and more experienced players happy to explain rules and give advice (in a non-condescending way). Players may be building relationships in this way by being vulnerable to each other as they learn how to play (Hirsch and Clark 2019, 240). Ulfgar especially has tried to be intentional about making people of all genders, sexual orientations, and skin colors feel welcome, understanding that *D&D* players can often skew cis, white, and male. As Gault (2020) puts it, "It's a game that was dominated by white dudes for decades" (para. 1).

Both libraries have made an effort to create a safe space through the intentional, consistent presence of library staff and through the use of library spaces, both physical and virtual, as a dedicated place for the games. The library staff can help to maintain a welcoming environment by assisting players in finding and accessing resources or by providing a clear neutral party for players to alert if issues arise. The use of library spaces, both physical and virtual, provides a stable and neutral space for all players, which they can easily access and leave based on their own interest and comfort. Additionally the access to resources, such as Roll20 and official game publications, provided by the library can remove financial barriers which could prevent players from engaging with the game materials.

Some of the female participants shared that they had felt uncertain about playing *D&D* at first and did feel comfortable and welcomed in the library game. Six of the 14 participants mentioned gender inclusivity during interviews. Of those six, three were female and three were male. Both men and women stated that these library groups are welcoming to women and LGBTQ + players. In total, we interviewed five women, nine men, and no participants of any other gender identities based on their own statements. This means that most of the women brought up gender inclusivity and only one-third of the men mentioned it, which is perhaps explained by the privilege the men hold of usually not being excluded due to gender, and therefore not having to consider it. We have no statement from a transgender player about their experience of being welcomed (or not) because we did not have any transgender participants and were not aware of any transgender players in these games.

Nine of the 14 participants discussed the level of experience with *D&D*, again asserting that the library was a welcoming place and that more experienced players in the library games were willing to help train less experienced players. All players were new at some point, and although this experience was more recent for some, anyone might remember and appreciate being included at the table.

During interviews, many participants stated that they first learned how to play or had previously most often played, with friends and family. The strength of the library in the development of a diverse game community is that it draws from a much larger community than just immediate friends and family. Library games can bring different people together simply because it is a space that intentionally services the larger community as a whole. The library creates a space, specifically a safe space, where *D&D* can happen and provides resources including books, online platforms, and DMs to help make it happen.

Discussion

Players seem to want both individuality and community from *Dungeons & Dragons*. They want to play and experiment with their character and occasionally get to be The Hero, and they also want to make friends and feel part of the party. Although groups certainly can and do play *D&D* outside the library, the library setting helps deepen the sense of individuality and community that players feel, and exposes them to a more diverse group of party members.

Connecting with Hidi and Renninger's (2006) Four-Phase Model of Interest Development, library *D&D* games grab the interest of potential gamers in the community through advertising, maintain interest by providing a stable gaming environment, and encourage exploration by providing resources. Players become curious and motivated to learn more about *D&D*, other games, and the library. Many of the qualities of libraries that participants described as making them good locations for *D&D* are tied to interest, motivation, and

curiosity. This ultimately makes library games more sustainable as they hold players' interest. Both of the libraries we studied had offered online *D&D* games during the COVID-19 pandemic. Ulfgar opted to remain online, and Quarion returned to face-to-face meetings post-pandemic. The virtual pandemic games allowed players to maintain relationships and a sense of community during a particularly isolating time.

Library *D&D* games also allow players to feel belonging. Experimenting with vulnerability as their characters and as new players takes them down the "communal relationship path" (Hirsch and Clark 2019, 240). We noted that the young players, especially, used *D&D* to experiment with actions that are not part of their "real" lives. This was facilitated by an adult DM, who was also the young adult librarian. Riswynn knew and understood the need for these young people to be silly, while providing some grounding that kept the game moving forward. Players may experience the "achievement path" as they take the hero spotlight and the "group membership path" when the party defeats a dragon (Hirsch and Clark 2019, 242). We heard repeatedly from participants how important the Dungeon Master's role is in maintaining a sense of community. A good DM allows the players to drive the story and makes sure no one is left out. They build community and allow players to be individuals. Library games tend to provide DMs and often train them so that they are more likely to be "good." Chatting with other players pre- and post-game fulfills the "brief social factors path" (Hirsch and Clark 2019, 242). Because the library games are intentional about creating a safe space for gamers of all backgrounds and experience levels, this vulnerability and experimentation are perhaps more possible than in games outside the library.

These libraries communicate to library patrons that they are "a space for gaming" and a "space for everyone." The presence of the *D&D* games helps make them "a space for gaming," as well as the provision of additional resources that support patrons in playing *Dungeons & Dragons* and other games. At the same time, the library is different from game stores. Less experienced and female participants repeatedly mentioned being intimidated by *D&D* games offered at game stores. From the examples of Geertz (1973) and Nelson (2019) above, we see the importance of play for attaining group membership. The gatekeeping, or simple lack of patience, that women and new players experience from some *D&D* sessions outside the library prevent them from taking the first steps of joining in play. In other words, libraries keep the imaginary tavern door open so that anyone can join the party. Even though the Ulfgar games are still online, the library building offers *D&D* materials, and a physical location where players might see each other in person. Ulfgar has also mostly limited their games to library patrons even though meeting online could allow more far-flung players to participate. Their games are popular and space is limited, so they are making sure to prioritize their library community. The intentional inclusivity of the

library makes it a unique gaming space, different from other spaces in the geographical area.

The library has long been considered an essential institution to democracy. As Fessenden (2022) says, “Democracies are built on the ability for citizens to educate themselves and make informed decisions. Public libraries are one of the only places where information is readily available to anyone who might seek it out, and they often exist separately from the ever-changing nature of electoral politics” (para. 2). In this study, we see that the library can also contribute to democracy by facilitating experimentation with the balance between individual and community through fantasy role playing in *Dungeons & Dragons*. Our findings regarding the individual and party agree with Ess (2014). The individual must be valued for democracy to be valued, but there must also be a balance: consideration of the needs of the party and sometimes submitting to an authority (the DM). Perhaps, this experimentation can take place no matter where *D&D* is played. However, because *D&D* games can be very white and male, the game party is not that similar to the real-world community in which players exist. It is significant that a more diverse group of people gets to grow in their senses of individuality and community in a library *D&D* game. Participating in a party made up of people who are different from oneself may be an important experiment in strengthening commitment to the diverse democratic community in which North Americans actually live. The library’s unique ability to maintain interest in ongoing *D&D* games and create a sense of belonging keeps players engaged in this democratic experiment.

D&D allows players to experiment with the balance between individual and party interests. Library *D&D* games take this experimentation even farther by providing a reliable time and space to meet, quality game leaders (DMs), and an intentionally inclusive environment. Libraries are spaces for gaming and spaces for everyone. Library *D&D* games may contribute to a stronger commitment to democracy as players learn to value both individual and party needs. These games also continue the rich tradition of *D&D* as a game that was created collaboratively and grown by players.

Implications

A limitation of this research is the small sample size, meaning findings may not be generalizable to the larger population. Nevertheless, we suggest there are some implications for public libraries we can draw from this study, while also recommending that libraries learn about their own communities to discover how to best serve them.

Libraries are more than the books (and other materials) available for check-out. Libraries are also third spaces where members of the community can socialize or just be. Offering programs like *Dungeons & Dragons* fortifies the

library's identity as a community space. As discussed above, the library is unique and can be a meaningful alternative to *D&D* games hosted at game stores or privately among friends. The libraries we studied have modeled how hosting *D&D* can promote the collection, which can include print and digital materials related to *D&D*. The games also provide makerspace inspiration. For all of these reasons, other libraries may wish to include *D&D* as part of their programming.

Going beyond *D&D*, public libraries might try to learn about other gaming and social activities of interest to their communities that the library could choose to host. As a space that is for everyone in the community, and has the ability to provide related resources, the library may be uniquely situated to offer an alternative venue. For example, The Moth (themoth.org), and similar open mic storytelling events are usually held in bars. A library open mic might attract some of the same crowd, as well as adults who do not frequent bars, and teens. The library also has books and possibly staff who could help patrons craft their stories.

The librarians we interviewed already had experience with *D&D* and enjoyed it, making hosting games a fun part of their job. In addition to learning about the community, libraries may want to learn more about their staff and their hobbies. Library workers may have hidden talents that can translate into new library programs.

We recommend future research on library-run *D&D* games, including how libraries create safe spaces for all players, with a specific focus on how *D&D* may be suited to supporting marginalized communities. It would be interesting to see libraries experimenting with helping patrons intentionally create characters that take them outside their own experiences, as described by our participant, Ruric. Future studies might also consider how the library setting impacts other games or events that bring the public together to further our understanding of the library as a community space and a democratic institution.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

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Appendix. Interview questions

Before we begin, Is it okay to record? Do you have any questions for me about the study?

- (1) Tell me a little bit about yourself.
 - (a) What experiences have you had with gaming other than attending this event?
 - (b) Tell me about some of your other leisure activities and hobbies.
 - (c) What else do you do in this (physical) area (near event)?
 - (d) What aspects of gaming, D&D or in general, interests you most?
 - (e) Are you willing to share your age?
 - (f) Any other demographic information you think I should know and you are comfortable sharing?
- (2) Tell me about how you started coming to this event.
 - (a) How did you first hear about this event?
 - (b) What made you decide to come?
 - (c) What keeps you coming back?
 - (d) Are there other gaming systems that you would like to see at events like these or explore for yourself?
 - (e) Would you like to participate in a D&D or gaming group outside of this event?
 - (f) Why the library?
- (3) What does this event mean to you?
- (4) What kinds of stories do people tell through D&D in this group?
 - (a) Themes you see repeatedly
 - (b) Anything that has surprised you?
- (5) What is your style as DM? (for DMs only)
 - (a) How much do you stick to a plan or improvise?
 - (b) How much do you moderate player discussions?
 - (c) What do you see as the role of the DM?
- (6) What happens when people break the rules?
- (7) Tell me about your favorite moment from tonight (or a recent game). Why is it a favorite?
- (8) Do you have a gaming moment or story, that has really impacted how you see the game?
- (9) How do you relate to your game character?
 - (a) How are your personalities similar or different?
 - (b) What motivates your character?
- (10) Why did you make _____ choice during the game?
- (11) Who comes to this event?
- (12) What advice would you give to a new D&D player?
 - (a) What would you say are the three most important things to keep in mind as a player while participating in the game? What helps everything run smoothly and helps everyone have a good time.
 - (b) What is something you would recommend GM's keep in mind when running the game to make sure that the game is collaborative?
 - (c) Would you like to try running a D&D game yourself?
 - (d) Is gaming something you would like to get friends and or family involved in?
- (13) What else do you think I should ask you?

Suggested by player, optional additional questions:

- Do you currently (or previously) come from a professional creative background such as writing, theater, art, etc? If so, do you think that side of you helps with the current game sessions? How so?
- Have you ever watched D&D campaigns (eg Critical Role, RealmSmith, Dice/Camera/Action, BlueBoxRPG, Dimension 20, etc) on the internet via twitch/youtube/or other technology? Which ones? What makes them interesting to watch?
- Do you feel that playing D&D has helped you in any way (eg mentally, emotionally)? Do you feel comfortable saying what that might be?
- For more experienced players:
 - Have you ever played a previous edition of D&D? (eg AD&D 2E, 3E, 3.5E, 4E)
 - Do you find that the current edition is better than any previous ones or worse and why?
 - In your opinion, what is it about 5E that makes it easier for new players to start with over a previous edition?
 - What is your opinion regarding children playing D&D (or other RPGs like it) and the potential development of their creativity in academics and life?